

How not to mess up your job talk

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Sep 11, 2026

A talk is an optimization problem

- Maximize weighted understanding.
- Attention is chosen by the audience.

$$\max_{p \in \mathcal{P}} \sum_{i=1}^n w_i U_i(p, a_i^*(p))$$

p : presentation

w_i : listener's weight

U_i : understanding

$a_i^*(p)$: chosen attention

The listener has an optimization problem too

- Value of following the talk.
- Value of doing something else.

$$a_i^*(p) \in \arg \max_{a_i \in [0,1]} \{V_i(p, a_i) + R_i(1 - a_i)\}$$

a_i : attention to the talk V_i : value of following R_i : value of other uses

Who is your pivotal audience?

Further from your work.

Not yet persuaded.

Needs to see why it matters.

w_i

The weight you place on listener *i*

Why would they keep paying attention?

Can I follow?

Do I care?

What else could I be thinking about?

Give the audience a direction

- 1 Question, importance, contribution.
- 2 Closest literature, setup, results.
- 3 Findings, implications, limits.

from [Matt Jackson advice](#)

Takeaways before details

The pyramid principle.

- Counterintuitive: training teaches evidence before conclusion.
- Evidence can be challenged in ways irrelevant to the conclusion.
- The takeaway sets the context for reading the evidence.

Apply it at the micro level.

- Open the model section with what the model is supposed to achieve.
- Takeaway, then the regression table.
- Have I introduced this notation? Will they remember it?

Seven slides ago is a long time

Definitions

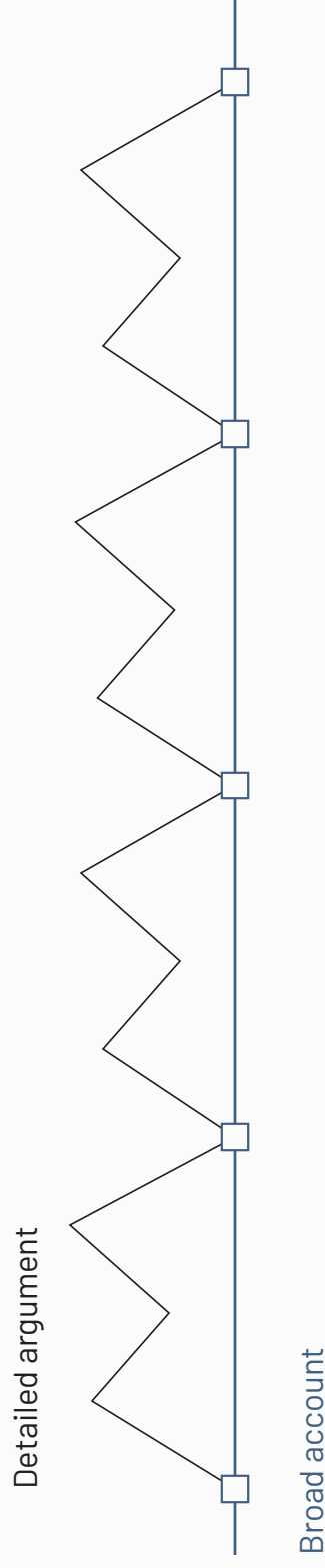
7 slides

Estimating
equation

You remember the notation.

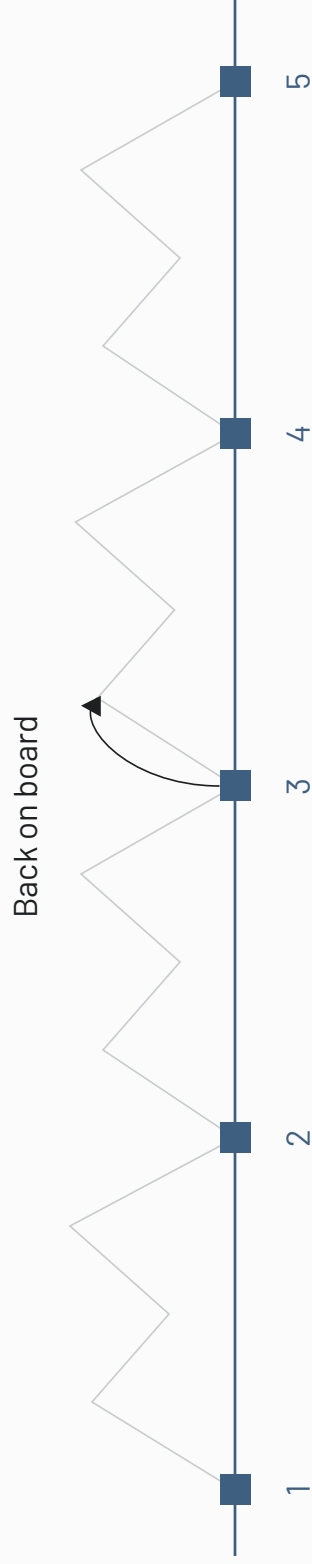
They may have forgotten it.

Not everyone follows every step



A detailed track. Stops everyone can follow.

Give people a way back in



What have we established?

Where are we going?

Come back on board.

Displayed does not mean understood

Displayed ≠ Understood

Build understanding.

Choose detail that carries insight.

from [Matt Jackson advice](#)

Simplify or remove the non-essential

Deciding what not to show is just as important.

Everything on the slide competes with your key point.

$$\underbrace{r_{n,t}}_{\text{Stock return}} = \sum_{\text{bin } b} \underbrace{M_{b,t}}_{\text{Bin-specific multipliers}} \cdot \mathbb{I}_{|d_{n,t}| \in b} \cdot \underbrace{d_{n,t}}_{\text{Demand shock}} + \underbrace{c'_t x_{n,t-1}}_{\text{Controls}} + \tau_t + \epsilon_{n,t}$$

$$\underbrace{r_{n,t}}_{\text{Stock return}} = M_{b,t} \cdot \underbrace{d_{n,t}}_{\text{Demand shock}} + c'_t x_{n,t-1} + \tau_t + \epsilon_{n,t}$$

where $M_{b,t}$ is the multiplier for stocks in bin b .

Let the slide unfold

Reveal it in pieces.

- Text: choose it so it reads as a story once you have worked through it.
- Diagram: let the picture emerge in steps.

Explain each piece.

- You have lived inside the picture; they are seeing it now.
- Waving at it and moving on leaves it unexplained.

Give people time.

- Breaks and interruptions are where understanding is built.
- Good talks advance through slides slowly.

About twenty slides carry the core

20

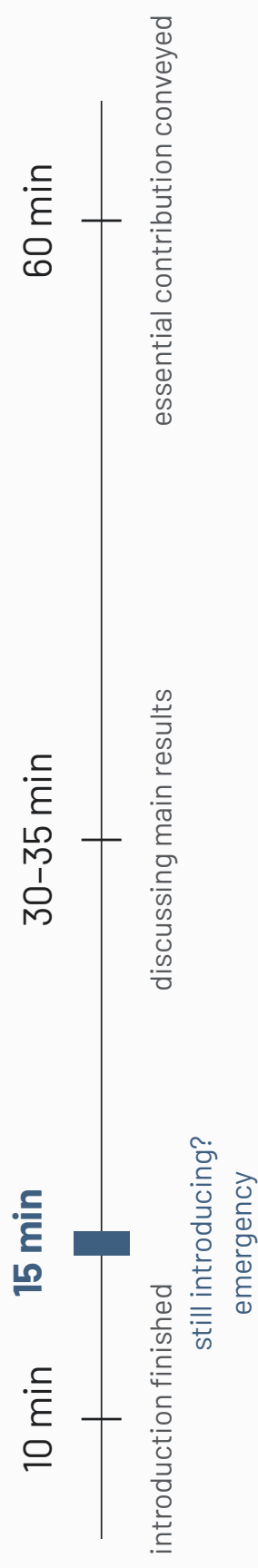
about

About 20: the core.

Perhaps 30: a 90-minute talk.

Make the important ideas fit.

Set deadlines for the important parts

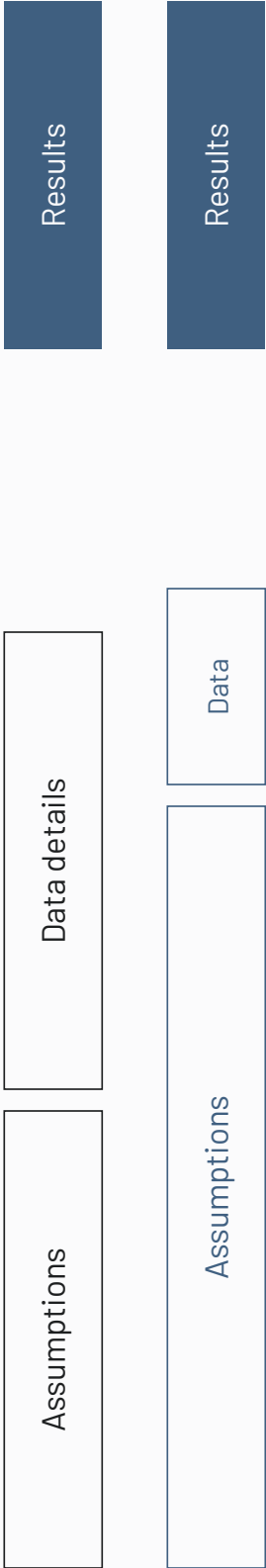


Landmarks for a long job market talk.

Defer detail—and return to it

- ¹ Give the gist.
- ² State the result.
- ³ Keep the promise to return.

Expand and contract as you go



Questions change the time budget.

Give some sections the short version.

Keep the landmarks in view.

Don't paste the table. Draw the result.

WHAT STATA GAVE YOU

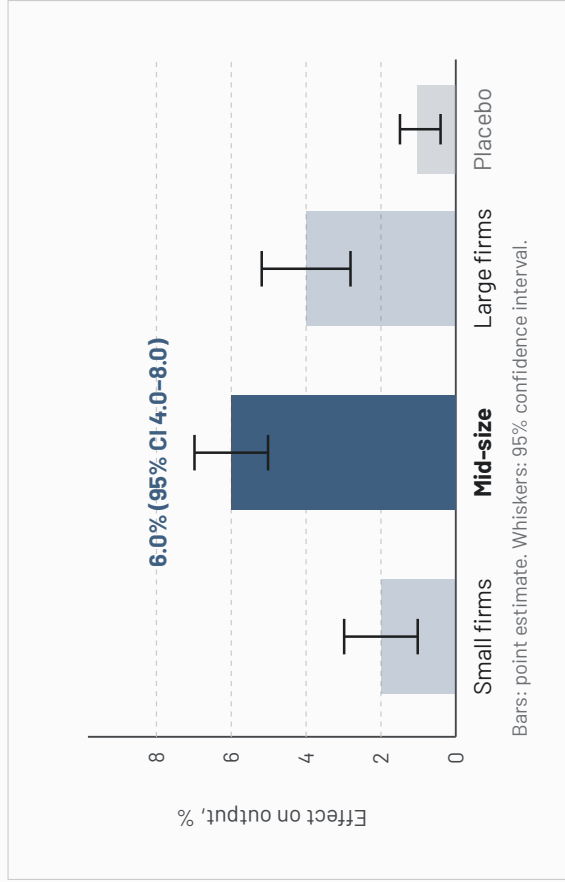
Table 4: Baseline estimates, 2SLS, robust SEs clustered at the firm-year level

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
$\log(z_{it})$	0.0413*** (0.0112)	0.0387*** (0.0108)	0.0402*** (0.0131)	0.0356** (0.0147)	0.0398*** (0.0119)	0.0371*** (0.0126)	0.0344** (0.0152)	0.0409*** (0.0117)
x_{it-1}	-0.0091 (0.0067)	-0.0104* (0.0059)	-0.0088 (0.0071)	-0.0112* (0.0064)	-0.0087 (0.0069)	-0.0101 (0.0073)	-0.0118* (0.0066)	-0.0063 (0.0070)
$q_{it} \rightarrow D_{it}$	0.1204** (0.0468)	0.1177** (0.0471)	0.1083* (0.0522)	0.1241** (0.0467)	0.1156** (0.0463)	0.1216** (0.0501)	0.1082* (0.0534)	0.1189** (0.0478)
$\log(k_{it})$	0.0076 (0.0094)	0.0081 (0.0089)	0.0069 (0.0102)	0.0074 (0.0097)	0.0068 (0.0091)	0.0063 (0.0089)	0.0079 (0.0104)	0.0072 (0.0093)
$\Delta \log(w_{it})$	0.0552*** (0.0141)	0.0531*** (0.0137)	0.0567*** (0.0149)	0.0498** (0.0163)	0.0544*** (0.0144)	0.0519*** (0.0151)	0.0486** (0.0168)	0.0558*** (0.0139)
Firm FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	Y
Year × Industry FE	N	Y	Y	N	Y	Y	Y	N
Region trends	N	N	Y	Y	Y	N	Y	Y
Kleibergen-Paap F	24.1	22.8	19.4	18.7	26.3	21.0	17.9	23.5
Observations	148,332	148,332	141,907	141,907	146,332	139,554	139,554	146,332
R ²	0.412	0.438	0.441	0.427	0.403	0.446	0.449	0.419

Notes: *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1. Standard errors in parentheses. Columns (1)-(4) use the baseline sample (5)-(8) drop singleton observations. All specifications include the full vector of pre-period controls interacted with the instrument.

“The coefficient of interest is here, in column three.”

WHAT THE ROOM CAN READ



“The effect is biggest for mid-size firms, and it is not noise.”

Leave room for discussion

Answer when you can.

Defer extended debates.

Reserve time to return.

from [Matt Jackson advice](#)

Return to the objective

$$\max_{p \in \mathcal{P}} \sum_{i=1}^n w_i U_i(p, a_i^*(p))$$

Reach the pivotal audience.

Help people follow and rejoin.

Get the results across.

from [Matt Jackson advice](#) · [Julie Fu deck](#)

APPENDIX

One model slide, built in nine steps

Chaudhary et al. (2024), as presented in [Julie's slide-design deck](#).

A ROBUST SLIDE EXAMPLE

The example on the next slide is from *Anatomy of the Treasury Market*

- Chaudhary et al., (2024); see [\[here\]](#) for the full slides

Context: time is very limited, so the model is condensed onto one slide

A ROBUST SLIDE EXAMPLE

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The design:

- Favor one dense slide over multiple slides
- **Narrator**: so a distracted audience can quickly skim through and reorient
- Progressively reveal the details and hide them later so only the main takeaway remains

MODEL FRAMEWORK

1. Data: Investors (***i***) are the FoF sectors; sample periods (***t***) are 2003Q4-2023Q4
 - Treasury defined as market portfolio of 1yr+ Treasury securities
 - Quantity data from Flow of Funds (FoF) + Call Report (banks) + TIC (foreign countries)

MODEL FRAMEWORK

1. Data: Investors (***i***) are the FoF sectors; sample periods (***t***) are 2003Q4-2023Q4
2. Modelling portfolio choice: log-linearization of any portfolio choice,

$$\underbrace{\Delta q_{i,t}}_{\% \text{ change quantity}} = - \underbrace{\zeta_i}_{\text{elasticity}} \times \underbrace{\Delta p_t}_{\% \text{ change price}} + \underbrace{\nu_{i,t}}_{\text{Demand shifter}}$$

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- Demand shifters: macro-financial factors + unobserved PCs + idio. shocks
 - Observable factors η_t^{obs} : e.g, VIX, Fed funds rate, inflation, ...
 - Unobserved factors η_t^{unobs} : principal components (PCs) extracted from granular flows

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 - Idiosyncratic shocks $u_{i,t}$: e.g., private info, sector-specific regulation, ...

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- Demand shifters: macro-financial factors + unobserved PCs + idio. shocks
3. Connecting quantities to prices: using market clearing, $\sum_i S_i \Delta q_{i,t} = 0$, where S_i is size,

$$\Delta p_t = \frac{1}{\zeta_S} \sum_{i \in \text{sectors}} S_i (\lambda_i \eta_t + u_{i,t})$$
 - Decompose the price response to factors by sector: $\lambda_S = \frac{1}{\zeta_S} \sum_i S_i \lambda_i$

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4. Identification: we assume idiosyncratic shocks are independent across investors,

$$\mathbb{E} [u_{i,t} u_{j,t}] = 0. \quad \forall i \neq j$$

- Granular instrumental variable, with optimal weighting scheme for asymptotic efficiency

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[\[Back\]](#)